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THE MIDDLE SEAT

Why TSA Security Lines Aren't as Bad as You'd Feared

Airports have reduced long lines with a surge of staffing and extra planning this summer; can it last?



By **SCOTT MCCARTNEY**

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The Transportation Security Administration appears to have saved summer travel. Barely.

After hourslong lines at some airports and public outrage over stranded passengers, the beleaguered agency pulled off a major restructuring between Memorial Day and the Fourth of July, dramatically reducing wait times even as summer air travel surged to record levels.

Denver's airport says it has had the 10 busiest days in its history this summer, but the average of maximum wait times for each day in June was 18 minutes, down from an average of about 25 minutes in each month between February and May. At Chicago O'Hare, passengers were stuck overnight in terminals after missing flights in May. But peak wait times measured by airport officials there fell from 105 minutes in early May to just nine minutes in the two weeks before July 4.

Nationally over the July 4 travel period, wait times for standard screening averaged 10 minutes and PreCheck lines averaged five minutes, TSA says.

There have been pockets of problems, occasional mornings of long lines in some cities when more TSA screeners called in sick than expected, for example. At one major airport, a senior TSA official says, keys to one checkpoint were locked in an office of someone off the next day, and it took two hours to get the checkpoint open.

"I think they're getting there. They still have a long way to go, but they're getting there," says Jose Freig, managing director of corporate security at American Airlines. "We all have collectively saved the summer so far. It's not finished yet."



Travelers make their way past a TSA security officer and dog at San Diego International Airport on July 1. PHOTO: MIKE BLAKE/REUTERS

How TSA dug out of its checkpoint quagmire is both a remarkable story of rare, quick change inside a big government agency and a tale of airports and airlines having to come to the rescue with money and manpower.

In just a few weeks, TSA imposed new oversight over its airport directors, put more agents on passenger screening checkpoints and found simple changes could make a big difference. One smart tweak: providing a barrel to dump out water bottles before they went through X-ray machines and brought screening to a halt.

Airlines and airports pitched in with millions of dollars of new equipment. They also added 600 contract workers to move bins and direct passengers so TSA screeners who used to do that could go back to screening and open more lanes.

Some changes were head-scratchingly basic, like creating a maintenance desk in the command center to quickly dispatch techs and alert headquarters to problems instead of the slower process of writing a repair ticket and waiting.

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In Denver, TSA experimented with an expedited lane open only to passengers with a personal item—no carry-on baggage. Flow through checkpoints sped up.

Summer vacations for screeners were limited; nonessential training was deferred. TSA also decided to slightly increase the number of people selected

to get PreCheck printed on boarding passes, even if they hadn't been vetted through the program, if they fit into "some specific travel demographics," according to TSA Administrator Peter Neffenger.

But Mr. Neffenger says creating a central command center proved to be the transformative change. The center hosts a morning conference call with local TSA directors, airports and airlines. The call started over the Memorial Day weekend with the seven biggest airports. Now it includes the 30 biggest every day.



Peak wait times measured by airport officials at Chicago O'Hare International Airport, pictured May 16, fell from 105 minutes in early May to just nine minutes in the two weeks before the Fourth of July. PHOTO: GETTY IMAGES

Participants review TSA plans and airline projections, address problems, create deadlines, share best practices and coordinate efforts. They discuss shifting staff at airports with multiple terminals and regions with multiple airports.

Once federal security directors had to report each morning on wait times and number of lanes open to bosses, airports and airlines, the pressure to perform escalated and TSA began functioning much better, TSA officials say. Wait times dropped, even at airports where staffing wasn't expanded. Instead of responding to problems after they happened, the agency was looking ahead, Mr. Neffenger says.

"We completely changed the way we operate. And I mean completely," he said in an interview Monday.

TSA got itself into the long-line mess by reducing its workforce on the assumption that more people would be going through faster PreCheck screening. But failed undercover testing last summer prompted TSA to tighten up screening. The agency reduced the number of unvetted passengers sent to PreCheck and slowed down standard lanes by flagging more carry-on items for inspection and requiring more pat-downs with body-scanner alarms.

When lines grew long in slow travel periods of January and February, airlines and airports started sounding alarms. By May, airport waits became a crisis prompting congressional hearings.

Congress let TSA move \$26 million from other projects to hire and train 768 additional screeners, who started in June, and move up to 2,700 workers from part-time to full-time. So far, TSA has converted more than 1,000 screeners to full-time screeners. That let the agency open checkpoints earlier. Another 600 screeners authorized by Congress are in training and will get assigned to checkpoints later this summer.

Travelers also helped by showing up early to airports and signing up in large numbers for PreCheck expedited screening. PreCheck now has 3.2 million people enrolled in the program, and another 5 million travelers get PreCheck access through the Global Entry trusted traveler program run by Customs and Border Protection. Enrollment in PreCheck is up 60% in the past six months.

At Seattle-Tacoma International Airport, passenger traffic has been up 10% this year and the airport was averaging a 45-to-60-minute wait at TSA checkpoints. Some waits were as long as 75 minutes, airport spokesman Brian DeRoy says. Mid-June through mid-July, peak times have been 20 minutes or less, with only an occasional 40-minute wait when cruise passengers arrive on Saturdays.

At O'Hare International Airport, scene of some of TSA's worst May meltdowns, the average wait is down to three minutes in July from a peak of 15 minutes, according to the city's aviation department.



Contract workers at New York's LaGuardia and other large airports have kept lines moving and freed TSA officers to focus on screening. PHOTO: LEAH LATELLA/THE WALL STREET JOURNAL

In Atlanta, Delta Air Lines paid to install two new automated lanes that speed up operations by automatically routing bags for checks and returning bins to the other end of the line. The lanes have large areas where five passengers can "divest" at one time so people faster at getting belongings into bins don't have to wait behind slow movers.

TSA says the new lanes have shown huge improvement. A standard line usually screens 150 people an hour. The automated lanes are putting up to 220 through each hour. American is spending \$5 million to install automated lanes at some checkpoints in its hubs. Other airlines are close to doing the same thing, and Mr. Neffenger thinks as many as 60 may be in operation by Christmas.

The next worry: What happens in the fall when the short-term fixes, such as liberal use of overtime, dissolve? Deferred vacations and training will take screeners off lines, and after Labor Day, airports and airlines plan to phase out contract workers they hired to help TSA.

Mr. Neffenger says discussions are under way to keep many of those contract workers on through Christmas at airport and airline expense, however, and TSA may pick up the cost in January.

“It’s not as bleak” as it might appear, Mr. Neffenger says. New workers will come online, more part-timers will get converted to full-time, more automated lanes will be in place and airline passenger traffic will shrink off summer peaks.

“I don’t want to see this be a summer fix and we slip back into challenges in the fall,” Mr. Neffenger says. “I don’t think we will.”

Write to Scott McCartney at middleseat@wsj.com

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